

CASE ID: 201911710380

EPISODE NAME: Sweden PEN Award

2019/11/12 - 2019/12/20

Sender: China (710)

Target: Sweden (380)

Issue: Contain Political Influence (1)

Final Outcome: Stalemate after Sanctions Imposition (9)

Summary:

On 2019/12/04, China threatened to sanction Sweden through “restrictions” on trade ties. In early 2019/12, and on 2019/12/20, China sanctioned Sweden by cancelling meetings related to trade. This was in response to the Sweden Poets, Essayists, and Novelists organization’s (PEN) decision to award the Tucholsky Prize to Gui Minhai, a critic of China’s Communist Party. Sweden PEN went ahead with their decision regardless.

Narrative:

The onset of the episode began on 2019/11/12, when China’s ambassador to Sweden, Gui Congyou, said: “We treat our friends with fine wine, but for our enemies we’ve got shotguns.”¹ On 2019/11/14, the day before the award ceremony, the Chinese embassy wrote to the Swedish PEN threatening that some people “shouldn’t feel at ease” after hurting Chinese interests.² Furthermore, the embassy website stated that if the Swedish Minister of Culture Amanda Lind were to attend the award ceremony for the Tucholsky Prize, China would “surely take countermeasures.”³ On the eve of the ceremony, China’s ambassador shared to the Swedish national news agency TT that if Gui Minhai was awarded, Prime Minister Stefan Löfven and every Swedish government representative in the cultural field would be banned from entering China.⁴

In early 2019/12, China imposed sanctions on Sweden through cancelling a meeting of the China-Sweden Joint Committee on Economic, Industrial, and Technical Cooperation scheduled for 2019/12/10.⁵ Following this, as reported on 2019/12/20, China imposed sanctions on Sweden

¹ “How Sweden copes with Chinese bullying.” *The Economist*, February 20th, 2020.

<https://www.economist.com/europe/2020/02/20/how-sweden-cope-with-chinese-bullying>.

² Olsson, Jojje. “China Tries to Put Sweden on Ice.” *The Diplomat*, December 30th, 2019.

<https://thediplomat.com/2019/12/china-tries-to-put-sweden-on-ice/>.

³ Ibid.

⁴ Ibid

⁵ “China cancels Sweden business trips after prize for dissident.” *Al Jazeera*, December 20th, 2019,

<https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2019/12/20/china-cancels-sweden-business-trips-after-prize-for-dissident>.

by cancelling visits to Sweden by two business delegations of Chinese trade and investment companies.^{6 7}

Swedish PEN had announced on 2019/11/04 that the Tucholsky Prize, given to persecuted or exiled writers,⁸ would be awarded to the Chinese-born Swedish publisher, Gui Minhai.⁹ Minhai was known for publishing books on the personal lives of members of China's Communist Party, and for this he was previously abducted by China.¹⁰ On 2019/11/15, Amanda Lind announced the award with an empty chair on stage to mark Gui Minhai's absence.¹¹ There were no reports of members of the Swedish government being barred from entry into China.

On 2020/02/25, A Chinese court sentenced Gui Minhai to ten years in prison for "illegally providing intelligence overseas."¹² The Spokesperson of the European External Action Service (EEAS), speaking on the sentencing of Minhai, stated that Minhai's rights had not been respected, and that the EU had since disputed Minhai's case with China multiple times.¹³ Sweden still recognized Gui as a Swedish citizen,¹⁴ and continued to fight for his release in the following years.¹⁵

⁶ Ibid.

⁷ Olsson, Jojje. "China Tries to Put Sweden on Ice." *The Diplomat*, December 30th, 2019.

<https://thediplomat.com/2019/12/china-tries-to-put-sweden-on-ice/>.

⁸ Flood, Alison. "China threatens Sweden after Gui Minhai wins free speech award." *The Guardian*, November 18th, 2019.

<https://www.theguardian.com/books/2019/nov/18/china-threatens-sweden-after-gui-minhai-wins-free-speech-award>.

⁹ Olsson, Jojje. "China Tries to Put Sweden on Ice." *The Diplomat*, December 30th, 2019.

<https://thediplomat.com/2019/12/china-tries-to-put-sweden-on-ice/>.

¹⁰ "Gui Minhai: Hong Kong bookseller gets 10 years jail." *BBC*, February 25th, 2020.

<https://www.bbc.com/news/world-asia-china-51624433>.

¹¹ Flood, Alison. "China Threatens Sweden after Gui Minhai Wins Free Speech Award." *The Guardian*, Guardian News and Media, 18 Nov. 2019,

www.theguardian.com/books/2019/nov/18/china-threatens-sweden-after-gui-minhai-wins-free-speech-award.

¹² "Gui Minhai: Hong Kong bookseller gets 10 years jail." *BBC*, February 25th, 2020.

<https://www.bbc.com/news/world-asia-china-51624433>.

¹³ "Statement by the Spokesperson of the European External Action Service (EEAS) on the case of Gui Minhai." *Embassy of Sweden*, February 26th, 2020.

<https://www.swedenabroad.se/en/embassies/hong-kong/news/statement-by-the-spokesperson-on-the-case-of-gui-minhai>.

¹⁴ Kuo, Lily. "Gui Minhai's daughter says China 'buried' his sentence amid coronavirus outbreak." *The Guardian*, February 27th, 2020.

<https://www.theguardian.com/world/2020/feb/27/gui-minhais-daughter-says-china-buried-his-sentence-amid-coronavirus-outbreak#:~:text=Sweden%20and%20European%20officials%20have,%27t%20been%20entirely%20surprised.>

¹⁵ "Gui Minhai." *PEN America*. <https://pen.org/individual-case/gui-minhai>.